CUSTOMER / PROJECT **Multinational enterprise · Invoice processing** FDE / TEAM **Team 6** DISCOVERY STAGE **Initial discovery** DATE **31 Oct 2026**

01 CUSTOMER & STAKEHOLDERS

Who owns the problem? Who uses the process? Who makes decisions?

- F Multinational organisation operating across several countries, with a large network of suppliers providing products, technology, facilities management, maintenance, consulting and other business services.
- F **Process owner:** the Finance Shared Services team, which receives, validates, processes and pays supplier invoices. The Accounts Payable (AP) team receives invoices and performs the checks before payment approval.
- F **Sponsor:** the CFO, who led the first discovery meeting. The technology team suggested AI may help.
- F **Also involved:** procurement teams and business owners (resolve discrepancies and give approvals) and suppliers (submit invoices and ask about status).
- U Who owns the problem end to end, who decides, and who holds the budget.
- U Which teams sit in AP, procurement and the business-owner groups, and who is accountable for each step.

02 BUSINESS OBJECTIVE

Why change? What triggered the request? What matters most?

- F **Trigger:** the CFO is concerned about the efficiency and predictability of invoice processing. Finance leaders believe employees spend considerable time clarifying, correcting or chasing approval for invoices.
- F **Concerns:** processing delays, operating overhead, poor visibility and an inconsistent supplier experience.
- F **CFO goals:** improve processing efficiency, reduce unnecessary manual effort and ensure suppliers are paid on time.
- F **CFO:** before investing in another technology platform, understand the real problems and the business value of addressing them.
- U Which goal ranks first, and what delay and manual effort cost the business.
- D No technical solution is approved. Process changes, SAP workflow enhancements, conventional automation, AI-assisted capabilities or a combination are all open, and any recommendation must be justified by evidence from discovery.

03 EXPECTED OUTCOMES

What should improve? How will we measure success?

- F **The customer wants to:** reduce invoice turnaround time and repetitive manual activities; improve compliance with the three-business-day SLA; identify and minimise avoidable exceptions; improve visibility into pending and delayed invoices; reduce month-end pressure; improve supplier communication and payment predictability; and establish measurable financial and operational benefits.
- U Baseline and target for each outcome are not defined.
- U How SLA compliance is measured: what starts and stops the three-day clock is not stated.
- U What "measurable benefits" means in numbers.
- D Targets are set only after a baseline is measured.

04 CURRENT PROCESS / AS-IS

What happens from request to closure? Where are handoffs?

- F Suppliers submit invoices through email, electronic documents and existing procurement systems. AP receives them.
- F **Steps:** receive the invoice → identify the supplier and verify details → extract invoice number, date, amount, tax details and PO reference → verify against an approved purchase order → check goods receipt or service confirmation where applicable → identify discrepancies (quantities, pricing, tax, supplier data, supporting documents) → contact suppliers, procurement teams or business owners to resolve them → submit validated invoices for approval → record and process approved invoices in SAP → track unresolved invoices and communicate payment status.
- F SAP is in use, but several activities still involve manual verification, email communication and spreadsheet-based tracking.
- F Employees wait for procurement teams or business owners to respond.
- U Time spent and waiting time at each step; the share of invoices that reach each check or discrepancy step.

05 CORE PROBLEM & PAIN POINTS

What is going wrong? Which findings are verified?

- F **Delays:** some invoices appear to exceed the three-day period. The stages responsible have not been established.
- F **Manual verification:** employees compare invoice information with purchase orders, supplier records and supporting documents. Time spent is not measured reliably.
- F **Exceptions:** incomplete information, incorrect supplier references, mismatched amounts or missing documentation. Frequency, root causes and impact are not quantified.
- F **Month-end:** about 65% of invoices arrive toward month-end. Whether the pressure comes from capacity, process design, supplier behaviour, systems or a combination is not known.
- F **Visibility:** managers need to see invoices awaiting validation, clarification, approval or payment. Existing reporting may not support operational decisions.
- F **Supplier contact:** suppliers contact AP about invoice status and payment dates. The volume and cost are unknown.
- U **Verified causes: none.** Where delays occur and what causes them are not yet known.

06 BUSINESS IMPACT & BASELINE

How often? What cost, time, risk or rework results?

- F **Customer estimates (accuracy and definitions to be validated):** 10,000–11,500 active suppliers; about US$5 billion annual procurement spend; about 25,000 invoices a month; about 65% arriving toward month-end; about 60–65 invoice-processing employees; three-business-day SLA.
- A **Derived from those estimates:** about 385–415 invoices per employee per month (25,000 ÷ 60–65); about 16,250 invoices toward month-end against about 8,750 for the rest of the month; about US$16.7K average per invoice (US$5B ÷ 300,000 a year).
- U **Not quantified:** share of invoices over three days; time spent on verification; exception frequency and cost; supplier-inquiry volume and cost; operating overhead; how often suppliers are paid on time.
- D No financial benefit is stated until a baseline is measured.

07 DATA, SYSTEMS & CONSTRAINTS

What systems, data, rules and dependencies exist?

- F **Systems:** SAP (enterprise finance application), email, Excel and document repositories. Invoices arrive by email, electronic documents and existing procurement systems.
- F **Data involved:** invoice number, date, amount, tax details and PO reference; purchase orders; goods receipt or service confirmation; supplier records and supporting documents.
- F Existing reporting may not support operational decisions, and tracking is partly spreadsheet-based.
- U SAP modules and workflow configuration, what reporting exists, and where invoice statuses and timestamps are recorded.
- U Approval requirements, rules and other constraints: none are stated.

08 REQUIREMENTS & MVP OPTIONS

What capabilities could help? What is the smallest useful pilot?

- F No specific technical solution has been approved.
- F The organisation is open to process changes, existing SAP workflow enhancements, conventional automation, AI-assisted capabilities or a combination.
- F Any recommendation must be justified by evidence gathered during discovery.
- U Which capabilities would help, and what the smallest useful pilot would be. These cannot be defined until the causes are known.
- D No technology is chosen before the problem is understood. AI stays one option among several.

09 VALIDATION & NEXT STEPS

What must be confirmed? Who owns each decision?

- U The accuracy and definitions of the customer estimates (volumes, headcount, SLA, month-end share).
- U Where invoices wait, by stage (validation, clarification, approval, payment), and for how long.
- U How often exceptions occur and what causes them.
- U How much time verification tasks take.
- U Why month-end is difficult: capacity, process design, supplier behaviour, systems or a combination.
- U The volume and cost of supplier inquiries.
- U What visibility managers need compared with existing reporting.
- D The CFO is the known decision contact; other decision owners are unknown.

USAGE RULE Mark each entry: F = confirmed fact | A = assumption | U = unknown | D = decision

CENTER THE PROBLEM. VALIDATE THE EVIDENCE.